

The Morning Newspaper

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 7, 2026 · AUSTIN EDITION

94° / 71°

Partly cloudy, 30% rain, wind SE 8 mph

Tomorrow: 96° / 75°, mostly sunny

Sunrise 6:30 · Sunset 20:36

Waxing crescent

Weather note: Open-Meteo was rate-limited this morning, so today's strip comes from web search rather than the usual API fetch.

Wall Street's AI rally cools as yields and oil climb

The Dow, S&P 500 and Nasdaq all slipped Wednesday as bond yields and crude prices rose ahead of delayed Fed minutes, ending a tech-led run to record highs.

WORLD & TECH

Spain approves emergency housing measures after Barcelona unrest

REUTERS

Madrid's government fast-tracked new housing rules this week after protests over rents and evictions turned confrontational in Barcelona. The package leans on rent caps and faster eviction reviews, part of a broader European reckoning with housing costs.

China's AI-companion crackdown spreads to the big platforms

MULTIPLE OUTLETS

Beijing's new rules for "anthropomorphic" AI services, which ban virtual intimate relationships for minors and require a disclosure label on AI personas, have pushed ByteDance, Alibaba and Tencent to pull back companion features. It's the first comprehensive government framework aimed squarely at AI built to act like a person.

Broadcom's AI chip-financing loop keeps growing

MARKET REPORTS

Broadcom's roughly \$42 billion financing tied to Anthropic's multiyear TPU lease is the latest sign that AI infrastructure spending is increasingly funded by vendor-to-customer loans rather than cash, a structure some analysts warn concentrates

risk if demand cools. The arrangement covers roughly a third of Anthropic's \$125 billion five-year TPU commitment, and it arrives on the heels of Micron's blowout earnings, which had already lifted chip stocks to a second straight winning week before Wednesday's pullback.

MARKETS

INDEX	LAST	CHG
S&P 500	7,771.90	-0.60%
Dow Jones	50,988.57	-1.03%
Nasdaq	27,398.89	-0.73%
Russell 2000	2,802.76	-0.97%
VIX	15.66	+4.33%
10-yr yield	5.33	+1.12%

CRYPTO

Bitcoin	\$83,207	-3.47%
Ethereum	\$2,567.06	-5.34%

STOCKS

NVDA	\$238.94	-0.12%
AAPL	\$335.12	+0.45%
MSFT	\$527.44	-0.35%
GOOGL	\$345.04	-0.76%
AMZN	\$255.25	-0.41%
META	\$723.51	-2.08%
AVGO	\$371.10	-1.25%
TSLA	\$375.69	-1.31%
SPCX	\$167.79	-2.40%
BRK-B	\$504.82	-0.14%
TSM	\$473.53	-1.82%

Stocks fell across the board as the 10-year yield pushed toward 5.33% and oil prices climbed, pressuring the valuations that had carried the Nasdaq to records on an AI-chip rally built on Micron's blowout earnings and Broadcom's huge Anthropic financing deal. Semiconductor and megacap names led the slide, with META, AVGO and TSM each down more than a point, while traders waited on minutes from the Fed's September meeting for a read on where rates go next. Crypto sold off harder than equities, with Bitcoin down 3.47% and Ethereum off 5.34%, as the VIX's 4.33% jump signaled fading risk appetite. Small caps in the Russell 2000 slipped nearly a full point too, suggesting the pullback was broad rather than concentrated in AI names alone.

ON THIS DAY

In 1571, the Holy League's fleet defeated the Ottomans at the Battle of Lepanto, off the coast of Greece — one of the last major naval battles fought primarily between oar-driven galleys before sail and cannon took over. The victory broke, for a time, the assumption of Ottoman naval supremacy in the Mediterranean, though the empire rebuilt its fleet within a year.

FROM THE FEEDS

ASTRAL CODEX TEN

An Open Letter To Steven Pinker On AI — a direct rebuttal to Pinker's AI skepticism, worth a read before your next argument about timelines.

LONGREADS

Orange Era — a sweeping essay on how "orange" became climate and crisis shorthand, from wildfire skies to warning labels.

NAUTILUS

Creating Fake People is a Terrible Idea — a skeptical look at why companies keep building digital-avatar companions anyway.

NAUTILUS

Human Vision Has Quirks That AI Can't Match — what Magic Eye posters reveal about the gap between human and machine sight.

NAUTILUS

Is Criminal Forensics Bullshit? — blood-spatter analysis and drug-sniffing dogs get a skeptical second look.

PSYCHE

Want to be a lifelong learner? Don't go it alone — autodidacts, it turns out, mostly didn't do it alone either.

TRICYCLE

Deep in the Monastery Night — a quiet reflection on grief and retreat from a longtime student of Bhante G.

ASTRAL CODEX TEN

An Open Letter To Steven Pinker On AI

SCOTT ALEXANDER · ASTRALCODEXTEN.COM · OCT 6, 2026

A direct, substantive rebuttal to one of the most prominent AI skeptics, worth reading in full.

Earlier this month, frustrated by some of your social media posts, I challenged you to a public debate on AI.

I hadn't realized that debate offers are to New Media what chum is to sharks. My inbox was deluged by podcasters, debating societies, and general influencers, all offering to host. When I objected that maybe we should wait for you to accept before figuring out details, they all said great, that's absolutely right, they would contact you right away. Their people would reach out to your people. Their nephew knew your friend's babysitter and they were confident they could relay the message. They had already rented an empty lot near your house where they would place a speaker blaring "RESPOND TO SCOTT ALEXANDER'S DEBATE OFFER!" at max volume, day and night. I protested that probably asking you directly on Twitter was enough to get your attention, and maybe now we should give you some time

to make up your mind before pressing further, but they said that no, sorry, they'd already hired the team from Inception to place subtle debate-related messages in your dreams.

So I feel a little bad for unintentionally harassing you, and doubly so after you responded in your trademark reasonable and charitable style with An Open Letter To Scott Alexander. You write that in-person debates seem confrontational and not truth-seeking. Apologizing for any inadvertent offense you may have given with your social media posts, you nevertheless deny my accusations of personal attacks, saying that your primary contribution to the discourse has been reasonable arguments about why AI might not be so dangerous after all (which you go on to list). You invite me to respond to these arguments in the same spirit of respectful mutual intellectual inquiry with which they are offered.



Continued online (full article about 10494 words). Scan, or visit <https://www.astralcodexten.com/p/an-open-letter-to-steven-pinker-on>

LONGREADS

Orange Era

BRENDAN FITZGERALD · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 6, 2026

A sweeping cultural history of how orange became the color of crisis, from wildfire skies to warning labels.

A quarter-century ago, after a deadly terrorist attack raised fiery explosions from the World Trade Center buildings, the US Department of Homeland Security introduced a color-coded advisory system, under which orange signified "High Risk of Terrorist Activities." For many people, including Dushko Petrovich Córdova, "this ambient, lingering orange signaled that emergency was continuous, a new way of living." Ours is a world of prison jumpsuits and Home Depot, leaders with an affinity for fake tans and "aptitude for the orange of perpetual crisis," public health maps of infection rates painted various shades of orange to mark severity, a sky dyed orange by wildfire smoke. We are inundated by the color; it feels, at times, inescapable. Is it really? Follow Córdova to the brilliant end of this stunner.

Once, in the late '90s, a few years before the dawn of the orange era, I found myself in Montreal for a friend's wedding. There was a wildfire nearby, and I remember trying to capture the eerie effect of the atmosphere turning orange with the disposable cameras that had been handed out to all the guests. The resulting pictures looked underexposed and nothing more, the otherworldly orange haze rendered mostly regular gray.

So, decades later, in 2023, when photos of smoke from yet another Canadian wildfire began to appear on social media, I was surprised by how well digital photography had captured what had proved so elusive in the late disposable-camera era. The best civilian shot I saw was of the scenery through a window.



Continued online (full article about 387 words). Scan, or visit <https://longreads.com/2026/10/06/orange-warning-crisis-climate-covid-wildfire/>

NAUTILUS

Creating Fake People is a Terrible Idea

ANIL SETH · NAUTILUS.US · OCT 7, 2026

A skeptical case against the AI-avatar industry, timely given this week's crackdown in China.

A few days ago the “human computing company” Tavos announced a product called Griffin. Griffin is a “human interaction model.” Supposedly, it is the first AI product to pass a video version of the Turing Test, meaning that real people cannot tell the difference between talking to Griffin and talking to a real person—even when audio and video are allowed.

This is a terrible development. The consequences for society are likely to be disastrous—perhaps even worse than the havoc wrought by social media. People will be scammed out of their savings, mental illness will explode, loneliness will be exploited. Collectively we’ll become less able to tell reality from fantasy, tearing at the fabric of a society already under considerable stress. Many more horrors will likely follow that we can’t even conceive of yet. (Here’s one

suggestion: How about people deliberately abusing their digital avatars to satisfy the darkest corners of their psychology?)

Creating fake people and sending them out into the world should not be permitted, let alone celebrated. How on Earth did we get here?

I first thought about this nearly a decade ago, at a conference in New York on technology and storytelling. One presentation by a generative AI company provided a perfect illustration of the slippery slope towards fake people.

Their pitch started reasonably enough. The speaker pointed out that the survivors of the holocaust in World War II were dying of old age. This meant that German schoolchildren soon wouldn’t be able to talk to real holocaust survivors—a practice enshrined in German education to keep collective memory alive, so that history would not repeat itself.



Continued online (full article about 1141 words). Scan, or visit <https://nautil.us/creating-fake-people-is-a-terrible-idea-1285598/>

NAUTILUS

Human Vision Has Quirks That AI Can't Match

KRISTEN FRENCH · NAUTIL.US · OCT 6, 2026

What Magic Eye posters and other visual quirks reveal about the gap between human and machine perception.

Human vision is imperfect. Our eyes do not always represent the world exactly as it is. We have blind spots. We see after-images. We are tricked by optical illusions. But some of these imperfections may be adaptive features of biological vision rather than flaws.

Today’s AI vision systems are imperfect in a different way. They are very good at accurately mapping an object in physical space, but they can’t reproduce the ways that picture might be altered by the human visual experience.

Now, a new study from York University researchers suggests that if we want to make AI computational systems more like biological brains, these systems should be able to replicate the perceptual mistakes the human brain makes.

“There is a growing question in AI about whether increasingly capable systems will become more like us or increasingly different

from us,” said senior author and York University neuroscientist Kohitij Kar in a statement.

One illusion humans consistently experience is known as the “motion aftereffect.” After we stare at an object moving progressively in one direction, a still object can seem to be slightly offset in the opposite direction. This effect is similar to what happens when you step off of a rocking boat onto dry land and the world continues to wobble temporarily. The perceptual artifact may be a function of efficiency: The brain begins to anticipate movement and must adjust quickly when it cuts out.

To better understand the gap between biological and artificial vision, the team of scientists tested 79 humans, two macaques and nine AI vision networks on this motion aftereffect using a series of moving and stationary images.



Continued online (full article about 577 words). Scan, or visit <https://nautil.us/human-vision-has-quirks-that-ai-cant-match-1285580/>